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SPECIAL SECTION: THE IM/MATERIALITY OF PACIFIC RELIGIOUS MOVEMENTS

Win Neisen 2020

Transformations of historicity in the Paliau Movement (Manus, Papua New Guinea)

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Win Neisen is a local, indigenously developed church, that is the contemporary manifestation of the well-known Paliau Movement which started in Manus, Papua New Guinea, in 1946. One of its central doctrines is that reality is divided into two spheres, the physical and the spiritual. Win Neisen followers adhere to a millennial vision, that involves the final dissolution of the opposition between the two spheres. In this paper I present recent material on Win Neisen beliefs and practices in order to characterize its particular form of millennialism. I conclude that this is very different from the millennialism of the early Paliau Movement and argue that a perspective on different regimes of historicity is useful for explaining this difference. Finally, I suggest a possible connection between Win Neisen's emphasis on the material–immaterial opposition and its specific regime of historicity relating to the challenges of the present time.

Keywords: historicity, millennialism, Paliau Movement, cargo cults, social change, agency

Introduction

The aim of this article is to show how a focus on temporality and historicity provides an advantageous theoretical perspective on the major changes that occurred in the well-known Paliau Movement in Manus (Mead 1956; Otto 2021; Schwartz and Smith 2021), including its political impact, from its early beginning in the late 1940s until the present. At the beginning of 2020, I revisited the Movement, which in its contemporary manifestation is called Win Neisen, and my empirical focus will be primarily to provide new material on this latest stage of the Movement.

I have earlier argued that the opposition between material and immaterial has been productive in the comparative study of the Melanesian religious movements, that have been labelled as cargo cults (Otto 2009). My main point was that this conceptual dichotomy clearly revealed a bias in much of Western thinking about religious phenomena in as far as it rigidly divided religion from economy, mind from matter, and spirituality from material interests.[1] This dichotomy was challenged by the careful and respectful study of Melanesian cargo cults, a term that had its origin in denigration and ridicule (Lindstrom 1993): a cult (an extreme form of religious devotion) of cargo (meaning material goods, a non-religious category). Many studies of these movements have demonstrated the importance of material abundance and the role of religious experimentation in the attainment thereof, and have provided a range of relevant insights concerning these religious phenomena, such as the importance of "myth-dreams" understood as synthetic narratives combining tradition with Christian elements (Burridge [1960] 1988); the role of charismatic leaders (Lawrence 1964);

1. There have been very important and influential studies on the relation between religion and economic development (see, e.g., Tawney 1926 and Weber 1979), but these scholars do not consider economic phenomena as potentially religious in themselves.

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the understanding of "cargo" as a synecdoche for a comprehensive millennial vision and the continuing importance of the belief in ancestral and personalized agency (Schwartz and Smith 2021); as well as the motivating force of experiences of inequality and exploitation (Worsley 1957).[2] The study of cargo cults has further led to a critique of the term itself and even to a discussion about the ethnographic reality of the phenomena thus referred (see Hermann 1992; Jebens 2004; Kaplan 1995; McDowell 1988; Tabani and Abong 2013). Nevertheless, these studies have resulted in important contributions to the scholarship on religious and millennial movements in general, and perhaps the greatest theoretical gain of the cross-cultural comparison of cargo cults has been to expose the purblindness that the conceptual dichotomy between material and immaterial has caused in the analysis of the material aspects of religious and millennial movements in modern Western societies and the appreciation of the religious dimensions of capitalist economic expansion (see Comaroff and Comaroff 2000; Huizer 1992; Löfgren and Willim 2005).

The Paliau Movement has often been mentioned in the context of cargo cult studies (Worsley 1957: 183–94), but although cargo dreams and ritualistic attempts to force their realization have been part of its history, the movement is too complex, multifaceted, and long-lived to warrant the more narrowly defined label of cargo cult. What is particularly interesting for the theme of this special section of HAU is that the material–immaterial opposition has become explicitly articulated in contemporary Win Neisen theology and organizational practice, and is, therefore, important for the description and analysis of this phase of the Movement. Nevertheless, I will argue that in order to understand how Win Neisen is different from the early Paliau Movement, it is essential to zoom in on the temporal implications of its theology and religious practices. For this purpose, I will use the concept of historicity that has become widely accepted in anthropology and history as a useful analytical tool for understanding continuity and change and how this is differently rendered in different societies (Ballard 2014; Hirsch and Stuart 2005; Stewart 2016). There is no consensus about a precise definition but roughly the concept refers to culturally specific forms of consciousness and practices concerning the past and how these relate to notions and practices concerning the present and future.[3] The concept of historicity implies culturally variable connections between the various dimensions of time such as past, present, future, linearity, circularity, potentiality, measurement, synchronization, and multitemporality. Central for my use of the term is a focus on how these different forms of historicity may be constitutive of a sense of self and agency and how they inform understandings of and actions toward social change. Following Hartog (2015), I also employ a concept of "regime of historicity" to refer to the temporal constellations characterizing a wider area and longer period, as well as the idea of a "crisis of time" when the established temporal coordinates no longer appear to work, and the established "regime" is under pressure of breaking down and giving way to alternative forms of historicity.

To develop this argument, I will start with a longer ethnographic sketch of the contemporary situation of Win Neisen to bring out the movement's understanding and implementation of the material–immaterial opposition and to explore the key aspects of its conceptions of time and history, in short, its regime of historicity. In order to better characterize Win Neisen's specific regime of historicity and its current challenges, I then compare it with the early Paliau Movement, based on material from Mead (1956), Schwartz (1962), and Schwartz and Smith (2021), as well as my own archival and oral history research. Inspired by Richard Landes (2011: 3–36), who has developed a series of concepts to characterize "the varieties of the millennial experience," I suggest that the early movement appears mostly like an "apocalyptic millennial movement," in which the new millennium is imminent and requires dramatic action by the believers to bring it about. Win Neisen's ethos, on the other hand, can be characterized as "eschatological millennialism," where people await the end of history and the arrival of the millennium, but where the timing and also the mode of relating to this perfect state are more ambivalent. I will further suggest that there may be a relation between the

2. Concerning the pressure on and partial erosion of traditional exchange systems as a special case of this, see Otto (2009).

3. It is important to underline that this usage of the term historicity stands in contrast to an earlier meaning of the term as "historical factuality." In its present usage, historicity refers to the cultural differences between people's dealings with their past, and, by implication, with their present and future. See Otto and Timmer (forthcoming) for a detailed discussion of the different meanings and analytical implications of the concept of historicity.

greater temporal ambivalence in Win Neisen's form of millennialism and its particular articulation of the material–immaterial opposition.

Win Neisen in 2020

Before presenting an ethnographic sketch of Win Neisen in 2020, I provide a short introduction to the continuing movement of which it is the latest phase. The Paliau Movement emerged after the end of the Second World War, when Paliau Maloat finally returned to his native island Baluan in Manus Province. He had been a high-ranking police officer in Rabaul, when the Japanese captured this city, and had been held back by the Australian authorities on suspicion of collaboration; but he was never charged. At his return he presented his ideas for the reformation of his native society, claiming that he had been given this knowledge directly by God (Schwartz and Smith 2021: 141). He quickly gathered a large following, not only on Baluan Island but in many other villages, especially in south-east Manus, and started a revolutionary process of reorganizing village lay-outs, introducing new forms of collaboration, and abolishing the large ceremonies of the past, which he considered wasteful and detrimental to people's health. While initially the colonial government strongly opposed him, later it created opportunities both for Paliau and the villages that followed him, by introducing a native council system, schooling, and cooperative societies. Paliau became a very successful indigenous politician and was elected as the Manus representative in PNG's first House of Assembly in 1964.

Paliau's original vision had a strong millennial underpinning, and his divinely inspired knowledge was spread through a new cosmogony, introducing a new historicity and correcting the mission's representation of creation (see below). In this phase, religious and political reform were one and the same, but a certain separation occurred when Paliau took up official, representative political offices, that also involved people who didn't follow his religious lead. Over time he established a church-like structure, called Baluan United Christian Church, that originally was inspired by the Catholic teachings and ritual calendar. Following his political decline at the regional and national level in the 1970s and supported by his recruitment of highly educated young followers, Paliau renewed his church by elaborating and changing parts of its central tenets and liturgy. He also encompassed some of the Manus tradition that the Movement had rejected earlier (Otto 1992b). This was reflected in the new name of the Movement introduced in 1978, namely Makasol, standing for "Manus Kastam Kansol" (Papua New Guinean Tok Pisin for "Manus Tradition Council"). The word council in the name also referred to the Movement's aim to provide an alternative government to the one actually in place (at the time called Community Government). In 1984 Paliau claimed that he was the last prophet of the world, and the Movement changed its name again in 1989 to reflect its new global orientation. Since that date the Movement has been known under the name Win Neisen, which stands for "Nation of Win" or "Spirit Nation," "Win" being the new (and "real") name for God (see below). Paliau was knighted in 1991 and died shortly afterwards, on November 1, on his native island Baluan.

The Paliau Movement has been characterized by continuous innovation during its history but, since Paliau's death, it has also been impacted by various leadership challenges involving the proper interpretation of the doctrine. This points to new dynamics and politics of authorizing the proper knowledge after the demise of the divinely inspired leader and prophet. Such was the situation when I returned to Manus and Baluan in early 2020 to learn about the current situation. A burning question I carried with me was what had happened to the so-called Freedom House, a beautiful octagonal structure, that had been finished when I last visited the island in November 2017. The Freedom House was still closed then, as it awaited its official opening, which had been delayed by the death of the then leaders of the Movement. The house was intended to become the center of Win Neisen worship and had been built on the exact place where Paliau is said to have received the light of the Holy Spirit. To my surprise I found the house still locked and abandoned. I decided to bring this issue up during a service of the Baluan congregation of Win Neisen. In order to explain my choice, which may seem odd, I need to say something about the rather unique structure of Win Neisen worship.

The congregation maintains daily religious services, but the main one is on Sundays. The service is called *hamamas* (Tok Pisin for "to rejoice") and follows a fixed order of three initial rounds of discussion and exchange: *ripot* (Tok Pisin for "to report")—giving mutual information on what has happened; *toksave* (Tok Pisin for "to inform")—mutual information on coming activities and plans; and *askim* (Tok Pisin for "to ask")—time for questions. Next there is a sermon by a religious leader and the singing of key liturgical songs. Win Neisen services are led by a so-called "teacher" but are set up so that everyone

in the congregation can contribute with what they want to say. During the February 9 Sunday service I attended, the teacher, Suva Parangkei from Lipan, welcomed me and initiated the *ripot* by mentioning that the news coming from the world was bad: ferocious bush fires in Australia, strong competition between countries about knowledge and power, and a new illness that was spreading from China. He concluded that Lucifer was very active and successful in ruining the world. The last prophet—Paliau Maloat—had already predicted this, but as long as we stuck to Win, Jesus, and the Holy Spirit, we would be safe: with them resided the true knowledge. A member of the congregation joined in and explained that we human beings have a spiritual side and a physical side. We have to take care of both sides at the same time. The teacher followed up and confirmed this: we have both win (spirit) and we have a body. We should not use too much time on our bodies; there needs to be a balance. We are still too much in the material sphere, where death, illness, old age, hunger, and hard work reign. If we change, Jesus can come and establish his order of freedom, where these plagues of humanity will be absent.

I was surprised by this clear articulation of the opposition between immaterial and material, between spirit and body, which I had not encountered before in such an explicit way. As a friend of Win Neisen and officially welcomed guest of the Hamamas service, I was expected to actively participate in the discussion and exchange parts. During *ripot* and *toksave* I shared my ideas about the global crises and explained my plans for the coming weeks. Then in the *askim* part, I took the opportunity to table my burning question by mentioning that I would like to know when the Freedom House would be opened. It was obvious to me that this question caused some discomfort. Suva, the teacher, said that normally this should be answered by the executives of Win Neisen, but since none was present, he passed it on to the people who participated in the service. However, it became overwhelmingly clear that my question could not be answered by those present. The delay in opening the Freedom House had been caused by the untimely deaths of the two main leaders of Win Neisen, who were primarily involved in the preparations, Peter Kuwoh as deputy president and Kisokau Pochapon as president. The dates of their passing were written on the inner wall of the Haus Hamamas (Win Neisen name for the church building): "09.10.2015 D/President" and "25.01.2016 President." Their deaths had not only delayed the preparations but also created a leadership crisis in the movement. To get an answer I was referred to the new leaders, who had been recently elected—and not appointed by Paliau like the previous leaders—namely Noan Kanawi (president) and Andy Marsipal (deputy).

Through talks after the service, it became clear to me that the passing of the previous two leaders of the Movement had been a major shock to the Win Neisen followers and had created an impasse for the completion and opening of the Freedom House, the intended spiritual center of the Movement. I found out that the impasse was aggravated by a heated leadership contest, which also concerned the meaning and purpose of the house. Before turning to a description of the two contestants involved in the leadership contest, Noan Kanawi and Athan Paliau, an adopted son of the Movement's founder Paliau Maloat, I will deal in some detail with the Freedom House as this illuminates different opinions about the relation between the physical and spiritual "sides" of human existence.

The Freedom House as spiritual connection

The Freedom House is built on land belonging to Paliau's clan, on the exact spot where he is alleged to have had his main revelation from the Holy Spirit, who appeared as a bright halo light above the big stone fruit tree which is still standing there.[4] The only furniture in the House is a beautifully carved wooden chair and a table. The chair, often referred to as the chair of King David, is intended for Jesus. During a Win Neisen service I attended on January 24, 2016, at a time the Freedom House was still under construction, a Win Neisen follower explained that the likely reason that Jesus had not returned yet was that there was no place made ready for him. Therefore, the Win Neisen congregation in Manus was building this temple on Baluan, on the very spot where the Spirit had appeared to Paliau. Once Jesus would sit on this chair, the order of Freedom would be re-established. During the same service the local chairman of Win Neisen told the congregation that Jesus would come back as Paliau, or the other way round, that Paliau would come back as Jesus.

Asking who had been facilitating the building of the Freedom House, I was told that one person singlehandedly had provided the money for it, namely Itong

4. This story is different from the one reported in Schwartz and Smith (2021: 141), in which Paliau received a revelatory dream from God in Rabaul. It is likely to be a later elaboration of the stories around Paliau's enlightenment, clearly anchoring this in his own land on his native Baluan Island.

Batia, a woman originally from Baluan but then living in Lorengau, the provincial capital, where she ran a successful business. Her younger brother Sokol had been trained as an architect and had designed the building and overseen its construction. During my fieldwork in 2020, I had the opportunity to interview Itong.[5] She explained that humans are both spiritual and physical. If we live according to spiritual principles, we can avoid the suffering that is part of the physical world, such as death, illness, old age, hunger, and hard work. She built the Freedom House when she was ill. Now she has "gone spiritual" and is not sick any longer. "I stay in the Holy Spirit," she told me. "Nature is creation and will obey our wishes if we are spiritual. But if you try to do sorcery, you are choosing Lucifer's side." There is an obvious hierarchy contained in these ideas, with the spiritual sphere able to control the material one. There is also an indication of different temporalities between these spheres, expressed in the opposition between illness, aging, and death at the material side and the absence of these at the spiritual side. According to Itong, we all have our role to play and for her this is making money to do charity. Building the Freedom House was an act of charity, she was asked to do. The Freedom House is spiritual because it provides a direct link to Jesus and the Holy Spirit. She continued to say that there is only one good way to make money and that is by following the Holy Spirit. If you do that, money will come easily and will never finish. But if you follow the way of Lucifer, money will be corrupted; it will never be sufficient and will therefore lead to struggle. Again, we see here an opposition between continuing plenty and discontinued, harmful shortage, in other words between permanence and impermanence.[6]

Due to the sudden death of Peter Kuwoh and Kisokau Pochapon in 2015 and 2016, the opening of the Freedom House was postponed. Someone who worked closely with the two Win Neisen leaders on this project was Athan Paliau, an adopted son of Paliau Maloat and then Win Neisen chairman of Mouk village on Baluan Island. On February 19, 2020, I interviewed Athan at the Council Centre in Lorengau town, the area where the headquarters of Paliau's Baluan Local Government Council were established in 1964 when it was moved from Baluan island to include more villages on Manus mainland.[7] Athan told me that the death of the two leaders came as a shock. He believed that they were called back by Jesus because they may have done something wrong according to his plans. When I asked him about the relationship between Paliau and Jesus, he explained: "Paliau is the last prophet. It is true that he once said, 'mi Jesus tasol' ('I am truly Jesus' or 'Jesus and I are the same'). Jesus is not a physical person; He is a spirit and can assume any physical body to do His work. Therefore, Paliau and Jesus can be the same. One may say that Paliau's body did the work of Jesus the spirit." Athan explained that Jesus, on His return, will take His chair on Baluan and establish His government, which will become the national government and then rule the whole world. But this state of Freedom is not close yet, because Lucifer is still strong. Many things in the world are still going wrong. However, Athan continued, people could go to the Freedom House already now and talk to the chair where Jesus will be spiritually present, although invisible. People could consult Him about their problems, and He would relieve them of their pain. Athan also told me that the spirits of the dead do not go to heaven. They stay around with their living family members to support them, and they may intervene if there are conflicts between them. If the conflicts are not solved, the spirits may cause illness and even death. These ideas go back to pre-Christian beliefs, that are still widely held in Manus, but are normally rejected by the Movement's orthodoxy as taught by Paliau. Important for the present argument is that, in Athan's view, there is a material place (in the Freedom House) where people can connect with the spirit Jesus, who can also be Paliau, his adopted father. There is a strong parallel here with the traditional beliefs and practices around the—living and active—spirits of the dead (Fortune 1935).

In the interview Athan also emphasized how the organization of Win Neisen reflected the division of the world in a physical and spiritual domain. The physical side is ruled by the *lapan-pilapan* local government council consisting of the councilors of the participating villages. *Lapan* is a Manus word referring to a traditional leader and *pilapan* is the female version of this. At the

5. The interview took place in Lorengau on February 4. As most communication within Win Neisen, the interview was conducted in Tok Pisin, sometimes mixed with English expressions.

6. The Paliau movement has developed fascinating ideas about money from its beginning, being concerned with controlling money's dangers and employing its potential. There is no space to develop this complex topic here.

7. Later it was amalgamated with the newly established North Coast Council.

head of this government stand the president and the deputy president. The spiritual side is covered by the Win Neisen Hamamas Department, led by a chairman, a deputy chairman, and the head teachers. Baluan with the Freedom House is considered as the center of knowledge and thus of the Win Neisen Hamamas Department, whereas the Council Centre in Lorengau town is the center of the physical government. The last president (Kisokau Pochapon) and deputy president (Peter Kuwoh) were appointed by Paliau. Their death created a leadership crisis. According to Athan, there has to be an election but first there needs to be a proper constitution to regulate the election process. Many people believed that Noan Kanawi (originally from Baluan but now living in the village of Naringel on Los Negros Island) was elected president (see also the information from the Win Neisen service in Mouk mentioned above), but Athan contested this. In his view, all councilors have to convene at the Council Centre in Lorengau to discuss the process and thereafter appoint the new president. Athan stated that Kisokau Pochapon handed over all the documents concerning the Movement to him and declared him president on December 24, 2015, before Kisokau left Baluan Island and died on Mbuke a month later. Athan also claimed that the area of the Council Centre in Lorengau was given by the landowners to Paliau as a personal gift for him to do his blissful work. Therefore, Athan, as Paliau's heir, could claim the right to decide on the use of this piece of land, which is still considered as the government headquarters by the Movement. Athan was acutely aware that the conflict between him and Noan Kanawi was splitting Win Neisen, but he was not willing to give in unless a meeting of all councilors decided that this was what needed to happen. Athan's main critique of Noan appeared to be that the latter was changing things according to his own personal ideas instead of following Paliau's teachings and the decisions by the deceased leaders. This included, for example, the order of the Win Neisen Hamamas service, the design of the flag, and the appointment of the Win Neisen executives. "You cannot become a leader if you change Paliau's knowledge," Athan exclaimed!

Noan Kanawi and the Win Neisen millennium

On February 20, I got the chance to interview Noan Kanawi, who lived in the village of Naringel, about half an hour's drive from Lorengau, the only town and administrative center of Manus. Noan, who is originally from Baluan island, had been trained and also worked as a primary schoolteacher before he was recruited by Paliau into his new group of young and well-educated followers, helping him to revitalize the Movement under the new name of Makasol at the end of the 1970s. Having a special talent for music, Noan got the function of choirmaster of Makasol and in that capacity he has been the author and composer of a great number of songs that have become the backbone of Makasol and Win Neisen liturgy. Noan also became an official member of the Movement's "executive group," all of whom were appointed by Paliau. With the sudden death of Kisokau Pochapon and Peter Kuwoh in 2015 and 2016, he was one of the few remaining people to have been working closely with the last prophet until the latter's death in 1991. This fact may have contributed to the decision of a majority of Win Neisen followers to point to him as their new president.

During the interview Noan expressed his strong irritation about Athan's opposition to his leadership. He called Athan a nobody: "He holds no substantial position in Win Neisen. Although he grew up in Paliau's house, he is not a real son of the last prophet." Thus, according to Noan, Athan's claims to inheritance were false and, more importantly, were not relevant for leadership positions in Win Neisen. Unfortunately, Athan had been able to mobilize quite some people at his side and was thus splitting the Movement. This obstructed Noan's efforts to reorganize Win Neisen after the death of the previous leaders.

Trying to identify the major differences in religious convictions between the two leadership contestants, we discussed the chair that was placed in the Freedom House. Noan explained that the chair of (the biblical) king David is now in London and that a bloodline links the English monarchy with the Israelite King.[8] This chair should not be confused with the chair on Baluan, nor can the Freedom House be seen as the place where Jesus necessarily will return. Therefore, Noan asserted, the name Freedom House is wrong, because we cannot know if

8. These ideas appear to have derived from Herbert W. Armstrong's teachings about the Davidic covenant for the United States and the United Kingdom, which were broadcast widely in the Pacific in the 1960s and 1970s. I thank Jaap Timmer for this background information. See also Schwartz and Smith (2021: 398) citing Wanek (1996), who observed a booklet authored by Armstrong in Paliau's possession.

real freedom will start from there. Concerning the identification of Jesus and Paliau, Noan specified that Paliau is the mouthpiece of Jesus; when Paliau is uttering prophetic language, he is not talking as Paliau, but it is Jesus who speaks through him. We cannot know when or where Jesus will return. "That program belongs to Him," Noan told me, quoting words he heard from the last prophet.

The true aim of Win Neisen, according to Noan, is to establish a theocracy to prepare for Jesus' return. The way to do this is by reinstating the local government council system as originally conceived by the Paliau Movement, and further developed by the Makasol who called it *Lapan-Pilapan* Local Government Council.[9] This government was given by Jesus to humankind and needs to follow the proper theology which is the responsibility of the Win Neisen Hamamas Department.[10] Noan called this division of labor a "dual system," consisting of a material part and a divine one. "The body needs to eat rice and the mind needs to eat knowledge," he explained. Both are necessary, and therefore we need a government to feed the world and Win Neisen Hamamas to care for the spirit. When Jesus returns, He will occupy His chair and establish His government on earth. "Thy kingdom come," Noan said, citing one of the key Christian prayers.[11] We do not know yet where and when, but the signs predicting this event are already visible: "tribulation, war, apocalypse, climate change." Because Noan believed that Jesus would follow the bloodline of King David, who was the ruler installed by him, Win Neisen needed to connect (he used the word "align") with Jewish descendants in the United Kingdom and the United States, where it all may start. When Jesus finally arrives, a new era will begin: "millennium time."

It is useful to pause my ethnographic rendering here to articulate the main differences between Noan, on the one hand, and Athan and Itong, on the other. These differences concern both the question of place and the question of time. A major disagreement concerns the Freedom House as being a main conduit between the material and spiritual spheres of the world. In the version of Itong, Athan, and many others, the Freedom House facilitates that Jesus will return and start his millennial reign from that very spot. Before that happens, people can use the house to connect with Jesus and receive his spiritual support. In this version there appears to be a strong connection and even identification between Paliau and Jesus, leading quite a few people to assume that Jesus will return as Paliau (or the other way round). Noan took a less Manus-centered position, as Jesus will determine where and in what kind of body he will return. His version undermined the centrality of the Freedom House and the chair within it. Instead, Noan followed a particular interpretation of the Bible, focusing on a covenant between God and the bloodline of King David (see footnote 8), which thus introduced another kind of historicity, that of genealogical succession, in the dealings between the material and spiritual spheres. Although many Win Neisen followers referred to the chair in the Freedom house as the chair of King David, very few were aware of the story of the Davidic covenant from which this name derived. For many, if not most, believers the chair in the Freedom House on Baluan represented a special connection between the material and the immaterial dimensions of existence. In all three versions discussed above, the exact timing of the arrival of the millennium was unknown but considered as not far off into the future. In Itong's rendering it was possible for individual believers to enter the spiritual sphere already in the here and now, at least temporarily, by "staying in the Holy Spirit" and thus escape the lack of freedom that reigned in the material sphere causing sickness and death.

Win Neisen's regime of historicity

Before trying to characterize Win Neisen's overall historicity, I will summarize Win Neisen's cosmogony, which is inspired by the biblical book of Genesis, but includes some important differences.[12] In the Win Neisen version of the narrative, the original creator of the world is no longer called God, like in the early Paliau Movement, but Win,[13] which in Tok-Pisin refers to breath or wind.

9. *Lapan* is the Manus term for a traditional male leader, and *Pilapan* refers to a woman with leadership status.

10. Noan also calls this "Win Neisen Study Group," an older name that is rejected by Athan and many others.

11. Based on a Bible text (Matthew 6:10).

12. I base this rendering of cosmogenic time on narratives as told and retold during religious services, sung in liturgic songs, and written in small booklets, such as "Win Neisen Stori Buk" and "Win Neisen Teacher's Guide".

13. In the early Makasol terminology, Win was called Wing, Jesus was called Wang Jesus, and the Holy Spirit, Wong Holy Spirit. The trinity thus was composed of Wing, Wang and Wong (Pokawin 1983). Kais (2008: 18) writes

Win is the original ancestor spirit (*tumbuna*) of the world, who first made the heaven where He went to live together with the angels, whom He created. Win then made the world (*ples daun*) by separating water and land, and populated this with plants, animals, and birds, before creating the first humans, Adam and Eve. In heaven Lait San ("sunlight") was elected as the king of all the angels. His pride and disobedience are the cause of all evil. Lait San persuaded some of the other angels that they did not have to listen to Win, because their knowledge and power were equal to His. As a consequence of this moral transgression, they were thrown out of heaven and Lait San got the name of Lucifer. Starting with the seduction of Adam and Eve, Lucifer has been doing his evil work on earth by ruining this place and destroying its original perfect state of freedom as created by Win. In heaven, Wang Jesus, the first-born son of Win, replaced Lait San as king and ruler of heaven and earth. Another central spirit was called Wong Holy Spirit. The features of this spirit have morphed quite a bit through the different renderings of the story and in the latest versions She is female and mother of humankind. In all versions Wong Holy Spirit stands for enlightenment and the bringer of rules and laws.

According to contemporary doctrine, Win Tumbuna, Wang Jesus, and Wong Holy Spirit are present in each and every living human being, whose body is like a house for these spirits. Win, Wang, and Wong help to protect the people they inhabit against the maltreatments and tricks performed by Lucifer and his fallen angels that cause mishap. Thus there are two simultaneous, parallel yet entangled worlds, located in the material body and in the Win Trinity, in the physical domain and in the spiritual one: two realms that have their own laws and temporality. In the material domain Lucifer is active and has a strong impact resulting in a situation characterized by death, sickness, old age, hunger, and hard work. The spiritual realm is free of these vices and is therefore considered to be in a permanent state of complete Freedom. The name Win Neisen refers to the unity of the people who follow the road to Freedom in the company of the Win Trinity and the spirits of the people who already have passed away and thus have left the imperfections of the physical world.

The split between the two worlds, spiritual and physical, happened in cosmogenic time caused by the disobedience of some of the original spiritual beings led by Lucifer. In Win Neisen's historical narrative of the Movement, there has been a period when the unity was re-established, namely at the beginning of the Paliau Movement. At that time people had returned to the pre-fall state of Adam and Eve, when things were plentiful and the forces of nature obeyed human wishes, for example in the form of favorable winds for sailing, or the availability of abundant catches of fish. The knowledge that had been hidden from Adam and Eve after the fall was doing its blissful work again. After these prodigious beginnings of the Movement, Lucifer's power has been on the rise once more. The contemporary time is characterized by multiple crises, as mentioned during the Win Neisen service described above. All this is an indication that the final act in the cosmological drama is near. A new era of Freedom will be established when Wang Jesus returns to sit on His throne and establish His kingdom, which is a theocracy on earth where spirits and humans live together in eternal happiness and peace.

Based on all of the above, I conclude that the dominant feature of Win Neisen's regime of historicity is the expectation of a millennial end time. Their millennial vision involves the final dissolution of the opposition between the material and immaterial aspects of the cosmos, between the physical and spiritual spheres of human existence. This dissolution leads to an end of the impermanence that characterizes the temporality of the physical world, which then becomes incorporated into the eternal spiritual sphere. However, the key issue with the expected millennium is that the time of its beginning is unknown. People hope and expect it to be in the near future, but they cannot be certain of this in spite of signs that are read as indicators of its near beginning.

What scope does this historicity leave for human action? Overall, humans are seen as rather insignificant characters in a cosmic drama which is the ongoing battle between good and evil powers. But there are ways they can have an impact on this battle, as proven by the events of the early Paliau Movement, in the way this is recalled by Win Neisen today. These events of bliss and abundance were made possible by the divine inspiration of Paliau, which the Movement was able to

that the new name for God was inspired by Paliau's wish to have a local name for the deity instead of using foreign words. This accords well with the simultaneous indigenization of the name for government by referring to traditional leaders (*lapan-pilapan* council). One can surmise that a focus on local origin was a factor in the competition with other Christian churches (see also Falck 2020 on the politics of naming the central deity).

translate into the right kind of actions that kept Lucifer at bay. Unfortunately, this direct divine inspiration and guidance had been lost, in particular after the death of the last prophet. Building the Freedom House with the chair of King David in it was an attempt by Win Neisen followers to facilitate Jesus' return; to nudge the coming of the millennium so to speak. But this attempt was frustrated by the death of the two main leaders, who may have been doing something wrong in Jesus' eyes. Noan's solution was to restore a former government system that had evolved as part of the early Paliau Movement,[14] with later Makasol additions. It was a solution that provided a possible road for action, but which had little political traction and also lacked concrete plans for dealing with contemporary challenges. It was primarily backward-looking and considered getting the theology right as the main condition for creating the desired theocratic state. Thus, we have a picture of lack of action and even stalemate due to the struggles for leadership and the true knowledge, in the absence of the prophet and direct divine input.

The main characteristics are thus uncertainty about the timing of the millennium and disagreement about the action required to get there. Based on Richard Landes' (2011) terminology Win Neisen's regime of historicity can therefore be characterized as a form of "eschatological millennialism," where people await the arrival of the millennium but are uncertain about the date of its happening and are ambivalent about what actions to take to bring it near. This is a situation in which many institutionalized churches are caught and one that also characterizes most Christian churches in Papua New Guinea today. In the next section, I will first compare Win Neisen millennialism with that of the early Paliau Movement and then reflect on the particular crises of time that these regimes of historicity responded to.

Comparison with the early Paliau Movement: Historicity and agency

The early Paliau Movement aimed at radical social, cultural, and religious change of the indigenous society (Mead 1956; Otto 1992a; Schwartz and Smith 2021) and in the theoretical terms introduced above, this included the establishment of a new regime of historicity. It is important to take the colonial situation into consideration in order to understand the strong motivations that drove Paliau and his followers. Before the Second World War, Paliau had been working as a native police officer in different regions in PNG and had become aware that indigenous populations were experiencing similar conditions everywhere in the country (Otto 1998). He noticed the frustration people felt about the stark inequality between themselves and the white colonizers, who appeared much more wealthy, healthy, and powerful. Manus people, and Melanesians more generally, had a strong sense of autonomy and agency, that was challenged by their subordinate position in the colonial society and its exploitative labor relations. Trying to make sense of this inequality and to find ways to overcome it, Paliau reached an insight based on a triple negation (Otto 1992a). First, he concluded that indigenous cultural traditions held the Melanesians back in their pursuit of wealth because of the wasteful nature of the big ceremonies that were so central to social life. These ceremonies also appeared to have a negative impact on people's health as they often caused a period of food shortage. Therefore, he wanted to abolish these big feasts. Secondly, he found that the missionaries must have changed or hidden part of the knowledge of God, because the promised healing and redemption had failed to happen. Finally, he reckoned that the colonial government had played a major role in the subordination of the natives, because they had required people to pay taxes and thus forced them to work for (low) wages. He further suspected the government of having forced the missionaries to hold back part of their divine knowledge that could have made the natives equal to the white colonizers. The solution came to Paliau as a dream or vision from God, who thus bypassed the white colonizers by providing him directly with the true knowledge.

This claim of privileged access to knowledge was an important source of Paliau's authority, which was enforced by his rhetorical skills and his creation of an alternative cosmogony that combined parts of the biblical book of Genesis with colonial history from a native point of view and God's revelation to Paliau. "The Long Story of God" (extensively reported in Schwartz and Smith 2021: 150–62; see also Otto 1998), told by Paliau in secret meetings with his followers, contained the

14. This is the Win Neisen perspective on the origin of the Local Government Council. However, the native council system was introduced by the Australian colonial government in different places in PNG. Its early introduction in Manus was a colonial political response to the influence of the Paliau Movement (Fenbury 1978).



triple negation of tradition, mission, and government, and pointed to Paliau as having received the right knowledge to guide the restauration of native society. The early Movement included several phases with intense cargo-cult-like phenomena, such as the destruction of property and other ritual ways to connect with the ancestors, for example via the care of cemeteries. These cult-like phases engaged varying groups of followers and threatened the political unity and impact of the Movement. Sooner or later they ran out of membership and energy due to the non-arrival of the goods and the active intervention by Paliau who worked to maintain unity in the Movement under his leadership.[15] In the first two decades of its existence the Paliau Movement became very successful in reorganizing indigenous society and forcing the colonial government to invest in local development, which led to impressive material progress, the introduction of health services and Western-type schooling.

The temporalities engaged by the early Paliau Movement comprised a new cosmology and history ("The Long Story of God"), explaining both the need and the possibility of radical change. This message was put in religious terms, as a return to the pre-fall situation of humankind, which was made possible by Jesus' teachings on earth, and his death seen as compensation "payment" for the original sin (Schwartz and Smith 2021: 158). The possibility of redemption, which had been withheld from the natives by the white people, was now restored thanks to Jesus' direct link to Paliau. The vision of radical change implied by this narrative had a clear apocalyptic millennial character and created strong motivations and high levels of energy among the members of the Movement, who believed they could realize these changes through the regained knowledge of the deity. The Movement's historicity was thus oriented toward comprehensive change in the here and now and the immediate future. The new understanding of the Christian creation story and its perversion by the white colonizers created a strong sense of regained agency, autonomy, and control over the future, which had been lost in the preceding decades of colonization and missionization.

Concerning the opposition between material and immaterial realities, we find that some of the central ideas that were later elaborated in Win Neisen cosmology were already present in Paliau's early teachings, as rendered by Schwartz and Smith (2021). In particular, the Tok Pisin word "*tingting*" is relevant here, which was used to refer to thought, mind, and spirit. Human beings were conceived of as consisting of both *tingting* and "*mit*" (flesh, body), whereas God and the angels were pure *tingting* (spirits) (2021: 152). But *tingting* is a complex term that also referred to people's emotional life, where any disturbance, for example through anger, was understood to cause illness (2021: 165). In addition, *tingting* referred to knowledge and understanding (2021: 166) and to the way God could control human beings and angels by making "their *tingting* insufficient" (2021: 163). Overall, the term pointed to "the creative power of mind" (2021:152). Thus *tingting* was a key ontological principle in the early Movement that made change in the world possible. Much of the effort of the early Paliau Movement followers was directed toward getting their *tingting* straight in order to effect the desired radical change to society. In my reading of these early statements, they differ significantly from the later Win Neisen elaborations of the opposition between spiritual and physical, in that agency was seen as unified and comprehensive, not being divided into an immaterial and material sphere, each with their own temporality, laws, and forms of government.

In the terminology suggested by Landes (2011), the early Paliau Movement can be characterized as an apocalyptic millennial movement, because for the Movement's followers the new time of paradisical conditions

15. Schwartz and Smith (2021) give a wonderfully detailed account of two influential cargo episodes in the early Paliau Movement, which they call the "Noise" (this was the indigenous term for a period of intense excitement and expectation of the imminent arrival of the ancestors with their cargo that occurred in 1947) and the "Cemetery Cult" (a name given by Schwartz to events in 1952–54, that centered on the refashioning of cemeteries). To avoid unnecessary complication of my narrative, I refrain from describing the relative differences in apocalyptic belief and fervor in these episodes, as my argument centers on the comparison of Win Neisen with the early Paliau Movement taken as whole. In my interpretation the whole period of the early Movement can be characterized as apocalyptic millennialism based on the enormous influence Paliau's millennial vision had on people's motivations and willingness to engage in radical activities to achieve revolutionary change. Schwartz and Smith appear to have a somewhat more restrictive use of their term "apocalyptic time," reserving it for certain moments of the early Movement, appearing, in their rendering, in the Noise and the Cemetery Cult (Schwartz and Smith 2021: 319, 320, 323).

was about to happen and depended only on their actions, which were guided by Paliau's divinely derived knowledge. This intensity of expectation and action was quite different from the situation of Win Neisen as described above. In order to look for an explanation of this stark contrast, I now turn to the concept of crisis of time, as introduced by Hartog (2015). In the case of the early Paliau Movement we find a colonial situation with stark inequalities between the colonizers and the local populations. The temporalities that were relevant for the indigenous people at that time derived from their ancestor religion with its mutuality between the living and dead; the rhythms of their reciprocal exchange system, constituting persons as active nodes in larger networks; the principle of payback in competition, conflict, and warfare; the millennial visions that were introduced by the Christian missions; and ideas of economic development and progress that were promoted by the colonial state. In this context, the relevant and acute crisis of time we can reconstruct is that of active agents in reciprocal exchange networks between living and dead partners (and competitors), being subordinated to the status of laborers ("work boy") and colonial subjects without political influence and with comparatively very little wealth, while being denied access to morally proper exchange relations with the dominating white people (Otto 2009). The missionaries had been able to challenge the power of the ancestors through the concept of an omnipotent God, but conversion to Christianity had not made the hoped-for difference. Therefore, Paliau's bypassing of the missionaries through a direct link to the all-encompassing deity created a highly charged situation, which afforded the reappropriation of agency and the promise of equality with the white people. Paliau captured this moment of crisis and transformed it into a vision for the future through his creative re-storying[16] of the native's situation and the design of new forms of society. In short, Paliau and his followers laid the foundations for a new regime of historicity.

The historical situation of Win Neisen is very different. In this phase the Movement has been operating in a post- or neocolonial situation with global inequalities, interdependencies and influences. The hierarchies within the country are not as racially marked as in colonial times, but there is a growing gap between those living in the villages and successful rich urbanites.[17] As an officially recognized church, Win Neisen finds itself in competition with a number of other Christian churches, many of which are actively missionizing for members. As a political pressure group, Win Neisen is recognized but poorly represented in governmental bodies. The temporalities that are at stake are a persisting millennial ethos, but now more of the eschatological type (which is similar to many Christian churches in Papua New Guinea); nostalgia for the early Paliau Movement, where spiritual and material redemption is believed to have happened; references to the value of traditional forms of leadership and authority; a growing sense of the potential of economic enterprise and the power of money in creating change; and the realization of global connections that have both spiritual and economic significance. The crisis of time is largely determined by uncertainty about the place of Papua New Guinea on the global scene, oscillating between the sense of being an economic backwater in a world full of conflict between powerful nations and the belief of being a place of great religious and cultural significance. By claiming to have the last knowledge about redemption, of utmost relevance for the whole world, Win Neisen asserts global agency. However, this self-reflexive sense of worth is weakened by the impasse caused by the present leadership crisis and related disagreements about doctrines and policies.

Apart from this striking contrast in temporal orientations and agency, there are also important continuities—with adaptations—in the different stages of the Movement, from the early beginnings to Win Neisen in the present. In addition to the central role of a cosmogenic story, which I have mentioned already, I would also point to the strong focus on knowledge and its impact on reality (Otto 2004). When Paliau started his movement, he claimed to have received access to knowledge that was withheld by the missionaries who had promised to give God's true knowledge. In the Makasol stage of the Movement, Paliau's "new knowledge" (*nupela save* in the Movement's Tok Pisin) was revealed, and on the way to becoming Win Neisen, Paliau announced that he was the last prophet of the world and that he was

16. I derive the term re-story from Escobar, Osterweil, and Sharma (2024).

17. There is also growing poverty in the cities, creating a new underclass.

providing the "last knowledge" (*las save*). It is important to realize that this concept of knowledge (*save* in PNG Tok Pisin) is not identical with the common meaning of it in English: knowledge as a representation of reality. Rather, *save* in the Paliau Movement (and *mapai* in Paliau's native Baluan language) refers to thoughts and insights that have a direct effect on reality, or, in other words, knowledge is something that engenders reality, it is a form of action. Therefore, it follows naturally that knowledge often was kept secretly, only to be shared with people who were trusted insiders or allies, as was the case in the early Paliau movement. This has changed in the newer phases of the Movement, especially in Win Neisen, after Paliau had explicitly ordered his followers to bring the last knowledge he had revealed out into the world.

Schwartz and Smith (2021), who provide a very detailed and well-documented history of the Paliau Movement with focus on the early stages, also see overwhelming continuities, while recognizing the differences in fervor and political context between the early phases and Win Neisen. In their view these continuities are based on a persisting cognitive tendency to personify causation, meaning that every impact—positive or negative—is perceived as being caused by a person's will and/or action, whether that person is a human or a spirit. In addition, they also recognize a widespread paranoid ethos, which is connected with this understanding of the world as controlled by personified agents. These two factors, personification of causation and paranoid ethos, provide a fertile ground for millennial beliefs, they argue. I agree that the psychological factors they identify are observable in some of the people's actions and statements, and I also recognize that personification of causation appears to overlap with my interpretation of the meaning and role of knowledge in the Movement.

However, in order to explain the stark contrasts between the phases of the Paliau Movement that I have described, we have to focus on the differences. In this paper I have developed the argument that we have to consider the different regimes of historicity under which the Movement has operated and the crises of time to which it has reacted. The early Paliau Movement reacted to a very different temporal and social situation than the contemporary Win Neisen, and as a result, and in spite of obvious continuities, their millennial visions, historicities, and corresponding agencies are as different as they are.

Historicity and the material–immaterial distinction

In this paper I have presented new material from the latest phase of the Paliau Movement, called Win Neisen. This material shows that Win Neisen followers made an explicit and central distinction between the material and immaterial aspects of life, often rendered in English as the opposition between the "physical side" and the "spiritual side" of existence. This distinction was reflected in Win Neisen theology and ritual practice but also in the organization of the leadership of the Movement into a branch that dealt with worldly matters and another one that concerned spiritual issues. The ideal relation between these two branches was conceived as a theocratic government system, with the greatest authority being invested in the spiritual leadership. The establishment of a theocratic system in the whole of Manus, and even the world, was the political aim of Win Neisen, as this would prepare humankind for the final arrival of a millennial state, in which Jesus would return and rule a world without want, conflict, and death. In Win Neisen's millennial vision the material–immaterial opposition would be finally dissolved, thus ending the specific temporality of impermanence connected with the material world, that was the cause of illness, hardship, aging, and death.

In the early Paliau Movement this conceptual division was not articulated in the same way, as the expected millennial change was considered as both imminent and complete: a total change of the coherent material–spiritual world. The Movement emerged under specific colonial conditions with great inequality that challenged the indigenous people's sense of agency, morality, and historicity. As a result, they were very motivated to pursue change and this emotional energy was transformed and channeled by their brilliant and charismatic leader, who created a millennial vision through re-storying the biblical Genesis narrative and synthesizing it with a new understanding of colonial history. Thanks to Paliau's keen insights in the political opportunities of the situation, the Movement was able to realize very substantial material and political improvements, that fueled and sustained the followers' enthusiasm for a long period of time. But the Movement's collaboration with the colonial government also meant a growing distinction between worldly and spiritual forms of organization, reflecting the Western model of the separation between church and state. Because of political divisions and

diminishing economic successes, the Movement finally lost steam. Paliau tried to revitalize it, partly successfully, by re-emphasizing the spiritual side of his Movement. He did this by introducing new inputs through the revelation of *nupela save* (new knowledge) and *las save* (last knowledge), which laid the basis of the Win Neisen theology and organization.

I suggest that there is a relation between the growing emphasis on the material–immaterial distinction and the new forms of historicity and millennialism—of the eschatological kind—that have characterized Win Neisen in its recent manifestation. The opposition between spiritual and physical aspects of life as so clearly articulated by Win Neisen allows for more uncertainty and ambivalence to cope with the continual disappointment about the not-yet-arrival of the millennium. The main responsibility for realizing the millennium lies with the higher spiritual powers, not with humans, who cannot know the precise date of its arrival and who have to cope with worldly matters through the appropriate governments in the meantime. The Win Neisen vision also allows for an additional ambivalence. As we have seen, people express the belief that they individually can attain a millennial-like situation, at least temporarily, by "staying in the Holy Spirit." This will cure or prevent illness and thus provides an added motivation to stay within the Movement, in spite of the continuing delay of the collective millennium through the return of Jesus.

To support my hypothesis, it is interesting and enlightening to look at the ideas of one of the greatest thinkers of the Christian tradition, St. Augustine, who as bishop of Hippo had to deal with the strong millennial tendencies of the early Catholic church in the fourth and fifth century AD. He made a clear distinction between the divine and the world of space and history, in which we live, the "saeculum," which was a messy world, a "corpus permixtum," in which good and evil mingled (see Landes 2011: 7). When discussing three opinions about how to inform people about the end of history and the beginning of the millennium, he found it a bad idea to say "soon," because this could lead to disappointment and loss of faith. He also didn't like saying "later" because this could discourage the believers. Augustine's solution was to phrase it as follows: it can happen any time, but we cannot know when (2011: 29). Weber (1999) adds another relevant interpretation of Augustine's teachings. This involves the idea that, although we still live in the saeculum, the end-time has in fact started with Jesus' coming, and the church represents His kingdom on earth. Things to come have not come yet, but they are already present in the mind for believers to partly realize them in their lives (Weber 1999: 45). I find the parallels with Win Neisen's division of reality into spirit and matter and Itong's story of the partial realization of the spiritual sphere really striking. Part of this can, of course, be ascribed to the distribution of these ideas through Christian missionization. But in addition, and this is my argument, the division of the world into matter and spirit and its related ambivalences can be seen as a cultural mediation of the temporal paradoxes and crises resulting from the experienced hardship and injustice in the here and now and the unattainability of the promised, expected, or at least hoped-for ideal state of the world in the very near future.

Returning to the usefulness of the material–immaterial opposition, which is the central theme of this special section, this article makes three different but related arguments. Firstly, it points to the way the extensive cargo cult literature has contributed to a critical questioning of this opposition, revealing how the intercultural study of religious phenomena suffered from a bias deriving from the Western Protestant-Christian understanding of religion as dealing primarily with the immaterial. Secondly, the article demonstrates that the opposition has become an important emic ontological distinction in a contemporary Melanesian religious movement, Win Neisen, most likely as a result of global Christian influences. Finally, the article claims that the Win Neisen case helps us understand how the material–immaterial opposition can be used as a conceptual device to mediate temporal paradoxes, that affect people's sense of agency and change.

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